



SUBIR HALDER

THREE IS A PARTY: Karat, Bhattacharya and Jyoti Basu

Deng in West Bengal. For a while, the Bengal Marxist almost echoed the moderniser of the People's Republic: it's glorious to be rich. Nandigram was supposed to be his Shenzhen. It turned out to be a sub-rural equivalent of Tiananmen Square, with students replaced by farmers. The blood in Nandigram brought out the Marxist horror of dehumanisation. Initially, Bhattacharya's intentions were courageous, and they were a repudiation of the dogmatism of Karat and other apparatchiks who have only arguments to win, unlike the chief minister, who has a state to win. Bhattacharya's mistake was not his mantra of industrialisation but his method, in which the market was subordinated to the state—and the party. He said sorry at last, Karat didn't. The party chief told INDIA TODAY: "The incidents in Nandigram and the way they have been projected in the

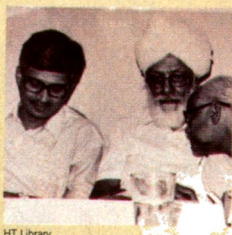
media have caused some damage to our party's image. But we are confident that when the full truth about what has happened there since January 2007 comes out, people outside West Bengal will also understand that there has been a political combination to convert the Nandigram issue into a struggle against the Left Front Government. Eventually, people will understand that Nandigram was not a struggle about land." (See interview).

At the time of the presidential elections in July, Karat, who did not know much about the Congress's choice, Pratibha Patil, went by the advice of CPI chief A.B. Bardhan, who had known her during his political days in Maharashtra. After Patil's candidature was announced by Congress President Sonia Gandhi, the Left came across reports in the media about the allegations against her. Though uncomfortable with the reports, they defended her in pub-

KARAT DOWN THE YEARS

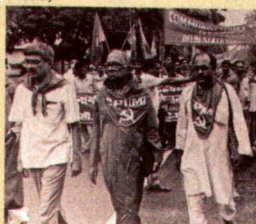
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Born in Rangoon, Burma, where his father worked for the British Railways. After his father's death, he moved to Madras.



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Graduated in Economics from Madras Christian College and went to the University of Edinburgh, Scotland, for post-graduation.

1 9 7 0

Joined CPI(M) and was sent to JNU to launch the party's student's wing. Assisted veteran A.K. Gopalan.



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Became president of the Students' Federation of India before going underground during the Emergency.

1 9 8 5

Elected to CPI(M) Central Committee and to the Politburo in 1992. Became 4th general secretary of CPI(M) in 2005.